Syllabus
Research Methods in Psychology
Spring 2025

Professor Info		Course Info	
Professor:	Nicholas Maxwell, PhD	**Course** #:	PSYC 4703, Sec. 201
Office:	OD 118	**Time**:	10:00am – 10:50am, MWF
email:	nicholas.maxwell@msutexas.edu	**Location**:	PY 102
		Office Hours:	MWF: 11am – 12pm; F: 2pm – 4pm

Required Texts:

Research Methods for the Behavioral Sciences by Frederick J. Gravetter & Lori-Ann B. Foronzo (6th Edition) (2019)

Course Objectives:

After completing this course, you will have a greater understanding of:

1. The basics of psychological research, including common research designs and research reporting standards.
2. The role research plays in developing psychology as a science.
3. Ethical standards of research, including guidelines for best practices and current issues in research ethics.
4. Written and verbal research communication

Attendance and Make-Up Exam Policy:

If you do miss class, you will be responsible for the material you missed when absent. Class attendance is ***required***. Each student is allowed ***four*** absences without penalty. Each additional absence will result in a 10% reduction in the students' final grade. Students will be responsible for the material they miss when absent. Students with ***more than five absences*** will be dropped from the course with a failing grade.

Excused-Absences: The ***only*** absences that will not be counted are absences for a mandatory, university-sponsored event or religious holiday. Written notification must be provided to the professor at least two days prior to the day of the event. Absences for religious holidays must be cleared through the Dean of Students. Students must inform the instructor of religious holiday absences by the 15th day of class.

No make-up exams will be given ***except in the case of an emergency***, such as a serious illness, a serious accident, or a death in the family ***OR*** in the case of a previously excused absence (see *Attendance* section above for what qualifies as an *excused absence*).

You must verify your emergency with documentation. ***You must contact me via email no later than 24 hours after the missed exam***!* If you miss an exam without a valid excuse, you will receive a zero for the assignment.

Course Requirements:

1. **Exams (400 pts total):** Students will complete ***four*** exams during the semester. Each exam will be worth ***100*** points (~60% of your course grade).

2. **Class Attendance/Participation (50 points):** Classes are most productive when everyone contributes. Class participation will be assessed on a combination of attendance, contributions to class discussions, your willingness to participate in class activities, etc. Class assignments must be submitted by 11:59pm on the day they are due (see course schedule). (~5% of course grade)

3. **Research Project (250 points):** During the course of the semester, students will be required to propose an original research project investigating a topic of interest. Students will propose their topic via email within the first 2 weeks of class. Students will then complete an IRB application ***(50 points; due 3/2)*** You will then submit a four-to-six page project proposal midway through the semester describing your topic, your sample, proposed methods, expected findings, and a summary of five peer-reviewed sources that you have identified ***(100 points; due 4/13)***. and will present a 10-minute PowerPoint presentation on their topic at the end of the semester ***(100 points).* *The remaining 25 points will come from your participation and feedback during other students' presentations.*** The total research project counts for 35% of your final grade.

   Late research project assignments will automatically lose ***10%*** of their point value each day they are late. ***Missing your presentation date will automatically result in a zero for your presentation grade, unless you have a verifiable emergency.*** You will have the opportunity to sign-up for your presentation day, so make sure to plan ahead!

   Acceptable topics include: Violent media and aggression, learning styles, different types of therapies, the role of genetics and intelligence, implicit biases/prejudice, cognitive benefits of being bilingual, can people predict their memory abilities, the validity of personality testing, etc.

Grades:

Your final grade in the course will be calculated based on ***700*** total points.

700-630:	A
629-560	B
559-490:	C
489-420:	D
< 420:	F

Email Policy:

You are required to use your MSU Texas email accounts for this class. I will not send emails to any other email accounts. I will also not send out class information to any other email address other than your university email account. ***Before emailing me about your question, make sure that your question has not been answered/addressed in the syllabus or elsewhere!*** When emailing me, please put the course number (PSYC 4703) AND section number (Sec. 201) in the subject line. This will immediately let me know which class you are in so I can respond faster.

I will try my best to get back to you within 24-hours (during the week) or within 3 days (weekends, holidays, if you decide to email me at 10:00pm on Friday…)

Cell Phones:

Unless you anticipate that you might receive an emergency communication, please turn off your cell phones in class. If you receive an ***emergency*** phone call or text in class, please excuse yourself and quietly leave the classroom to take the message.

Academic Dishonesty Policy:

Academic Dishonesty is defined as cheating, collusion, and plagiarism (the act of using source material of other persons, either published or unpublished, without following the accepted techniques of crediting, or the submission for credit of work not the individuals to whom credit is given). Additional guidelines on procedures in these matters may be found in the Office of Student Conduct: Office of Student Conduct

Cheating will not be tolerated. Any evidence of cheating on exams or written assignments will result in dismissal from this class with a grade of "F" and referral to the Dean of Students. Cheating includes, but is not limited to, using unauthorized notes of any kind during an exam, looking on another's exam, allowing another student to look on your exam, plagiarism, and self-plagiarism.

Desire-to-Learn (D2L):

This course utilizes the MSU D2L program for assignment submission. Relevant course materials will also be posted on D2L. Each student is expected to be familiar with this program as it provides a primary source of communication regarding general course information. You can log into D2L through the MSU Homepage. If you experience difficulties, please contact the technicians listed for the program.

Disability Services:

Any student who, because of a disability, may require special arrangements in order to meet the course requirements should contact the instructor as soon as possible to make necessary arrangements. Students must present appropriate verification from Disability Support Services (DSS) during the instructor's office hours. Please note that instructors are not allowed to provide classroom accommodation to a student until appropriate verification from DSS has been provided.

Midterm Grade Reports:

In order to help students keep track of their progress toward course objectives, the instructor for this class will provide a Midterm Progress Report through each student's WebWorld account. ***Midterm progress reports will only be provided for students with a grade of C or less in the course.*** Midterm grades will not be reported on the students' transcripts, nor will they be calculated in the cumulative GPA. They simply give students an idea of where they stand at the midpoint of the semester.

Change of Schedule:

A student dropping a course (but not withdrawing from the University) within the first 12 class days of a regular semester or the first four class days of a summer semester is eligible for a100% refund of applicable tuition and fees. Dates are published in the Schedule of Classes each semester.

Course Schedule:

Important! The reading for each day is what's expected to have been read *prior* to that date. Please note that this schedule represents *the ideal semester*! Any deviations from this schedule (particularly as they pertain to assignment deadlines and exam dates) will be announced in class **AND** posted on D2L.

Week	Topic	Reading	Assignment Due	Notes
Week 1: 1/20 – 1/24	Course Overview/The Scientific Method	Syllabus/Chapter 1		***No Class 1/20 (MLK day)***
Week 2: 1/27 – 1/31	Research Ideas and Hypotheses/Defining and Measuring Variables	Chapters 2 and 3		***Research Topic Due Friday 1/31 @ 11:59pm***
Week 3: 2/3 – 2/7	Ethics in Research	Chapter 4		
Week 4: 2/10 – 2/14	Ethics in Research	Chapter 4		***No Class Monday 2/10*** ***Exam 1 in Class Friday 2/14* (Chapters 1 – 4)**
Week 5: 2/17 – 2/21	Selecting Research Particpants	Chapter 5		
Week 6: 2/24 – 2/28	Research Strategies and Validity	Chapter 6		***IRB Applications Due Sunday 3/2 @ 11:59pm***
Week 7: 3/3 – 3/7	Experimental Research	Chapter 7		***Exam 2 in Class Friday 3/7* (Chapters 5 – 7)**
Week 8: 3/10 – 3/14	**Spring Break**			***No Class this week!***
Week 9: 3/17 – 3/21	Between Subjects and Within Subjects Designs	Chapters 8 and 9		
Week 10: 3/24 – 3/28	Non-Experimental Designs	Chapter 10		***No Class Friday 3/28***

Week 11: 3/31 – 4/4	Factorial Designs	Chapter 11		***Exam 3 in Class Friday 4/4* (Chapters 8 – 11)**
Week 12: 4/7 – 4/11	Correlational Research	Chapter 12		***Research Proposal Papers due Sunday 4/13 @ 11:59pm***
Week 13: 4/14 – 4/18	Descriptive Research	Chapter 13		***No class Friday 4/18 (Easter Holiday)***
Week 14: 4/21 – 4/25	Single Case Research Designs and Survey Research	Chapter 14/Survey Research Slides		
Week 15: 4/28 – 5/2	Survey Research	Survey Research Slides		***No Class Wednesday 4/30*** ***Exam 4 in Class Friday 5/2****
Week 16: 5/5 – 5/9	Student Presentations			**In class presentations on assigned date.**